much about the technical aspects. In any case, Anil Kumble once explained to me that to bowl leg-spin consistently, I needed to hold my shoulder while bowling. What he meant was that I needed to have my fingers, arm and shoulder position aligned for longer. It was something I could never get the hang of, so I just left it to my natural ability, and I rarely bowled more than three overs at a stretch in a match unless I was bowling really well. This gave me licence to experiment and I could give the ball a rip if I wished to. At Kochi it all worked beautifully. I finished with 5–32 and Australia were bowled out for 268 in the forty-sixth over. We had won the match by 41 runs.

We continued the good form against the Australians in the next ODI at the Green Park stadium in Kanpur on 7 April. It was a low-scoring encounter, with the Australians setting us 222 to chase. The pitch was keeping low and I had figured out that the best option was to be aggressive at the start. I got another hundred in this match and remember one particular shot against Tom Moody. Even before he had released the ball, I stepped out and he followed me. The ball was down the leg side and, having stepped out of my crease, I wasn't in the best position to meet the delivery. I connected on the full but played it slightly off-balance. To my surprise, the ball landed in the stands, way beyond the boundary. Later in the innings I came down the wicket to Warne and this time the ball hit the bottom of my bat. Warne immediately screamed 'Catch it!' – only to see the ball soar over the long-on fielder and land 10 yards behind him for another six. I hit seven in all and we won the game comfortably, to book a spot in the final, which we unfortunately lost to Australia. It was disappointing after winning all the group matches and it resulted in an imperfect end to the tour.

Coca-Cola Cup, April 1998

Soon after the series was over we went to Sharjah for yet another tri-series, with Australia and New Zealand. It is a tournament I remember well because I played some of my best cricket and because of an incident that took place on the flight out to Sharjah. The Indian team included two relative newcomers, Harbhajan Singh and Harvinder Singh, the medium-fast bowler. The flight attendant asked both of them if they wanted soup. Not very good with English at the time, Harvinder may not have understood the question. I overheard Harvinder tell Bhajji that it was